The Welfare Effects of Social Media

AIW 2026 T3

Workshop 4 - Text Summaries and Literature Reviews

Andre Henriques

Visual Abstract

Do social media breaks improve mood? What prior experiments show, and the gap this study addresses.

FULL DEACTIVATION	PARTIAL RESTRICTION	BRIEF ABSTINENCE
Multi-week, complete break	*Daily time cap*	*1–10 days off*
▲ **Allcott et al., 2020** N = 1,661 adults · 4 weeks Small gains in subjective well-being	▲ **Faulhaber et al., 2023** N = 230 · 30 min/day · 2 weeks Higher positive affect; less anxiety, loneliness ● **Collis & Eggers, 2022** N = 122 · 10 min/day · ~9 weeks No significant effect	▼ **Walsh et al., 2024** N = 338 · 8–10 days More negative emotion (SM arm, n = 67) ● **Przybylski et al., 2021** N = 600 · 1 day No mood benefit; lower relatedness
Modest benefit	**Mixed**	**No benefit / possible costs**

GAP Prior samples are adults or undergraduates; effects in adolescents are unknown.

THIS STUDY An experimental test of a social media break on mood in an adolescent sample.

▲ benefit ● no significant effect ▼ worse outcome · Sources: see References [1]–[5]

1. Draft Introduction: Prior Evidence

A widespread concern regarding the impact of digital media on psychological well-being has made "digital detoxes" and voluntary usage restrictions popular strategies for improving mental health. Experimental evidence in adult populations indicates that complete, multi-week deactivation from social platforms can yield modest improvements in overall well-being and positive mood. In a randomized controlled trial (RCT) with 1,661 adult Facebook users in the USA, a paid 4-week Facebook deactivation produced small but significant improvements in subjective well-being, including higher self-reported happiness and life satisfaction and lower depression and anxiety (Allcott et al., 2020[1]).

However, the empirical picture becomes significantly more nuanced when examining partial restriction (cutting down) or shorter periods of abstinence. Certain self-monitored restriction interventions have successfully enhanced mood: in an RCT with 230 undergraduate students in the USA, limiting social media to 30 min/day for 2 weeks increased positive affect and reduced anxiety, depression, loneliness, FOMO, and negative affect (Faulhaber et al., 2023[2]). By contrast, longer-term enforced limits often fail to produce detectable well-being benefits: in an RCT with 122 university students in Europe whose use was capped at 10 min/day for one academic term (approx. 9 weeks), there was no significant effect on well-being (Collis & Eggers, 2022[3]). Furthermore, brief abstinence periods or targeted social media restrictions can sometimes induce unintended emotional friction or reduced social connectedness. In a four-arm RCT with 338 university students in the USA, participants assigned to an 8–10 day social media restriction (n = 67) reported few benefits and increased negative emotion (Walsh et al., 2024[4]). Similarly, a within-person randomized trial with 600 undergraduate students across the UK, US, and Hong Kong found that 1-day social media abstinence had no positive effect on mood and led to some deficits in social relatedness (Przybylski et al., 2021[5]).

Crucially, existing experimental literature relies almost exclusively on adult and university undergraduate samples (e.g., Allcott et al., 2020[1]; Faulhaber et al., 2023[2]; Collis & Eggers, 2022[3]). These findings cannot be automatically generalized to adolescents. Teenagers navigate a distinct developmental stage in which peer connectedness, digital social infrastructure, and the fear of missing out (FOMO) play a heightened role in daily emotional self-regulation. Consequently, whether temporary social media breaks enhance or harm mood in

younger cohorts remains an open empirical question. The current study addresses this gap by experimentally examining the affective impact of a social media break specifically within an adolescent sample.

2. References

[1] **Allcott, H., Braghieri, L., Eichmeyer, S., & Gentzkow, M.** (2020). The welfare effects of social media. *American Economic Review*, 110(3), 629–676. https://doi.org/10.1257/aer.20190658

[2] **Faulhaber, M. E., Lee, J. E., & Gentile, D. A.** (2023). The effect of self-monitoring limited social media use on psychological well-being. *Technology, Mind, and Behavior*, 4(2). https://doi.org/10.1037/tmb0000111

[3] **Collis, A., & Eggers, F.** (2022). Effects of restricting social media usage on wellbeing and performance: A randomized control trial among students. *PLOS ONE*, 17(8), Article e0272416. https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0272416

[4] **Walsh, L. C., Regan, A., Okabe-Miyamoto, K., & Lyubomirsky, S.** (2024). Does putting down your smartphone make you happier? The effects of restricting digital media on well-being. *PLOS ONE*, 19(10), Article e0306910. https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pone.0306910

[5] **Przybylski, A. K., Nguyen, T.-v. T., Law, W., & Weinstein, N.** (2021). Does taking a short break from social media have a positive effect on well-being? Evidence from three preregistered field experiments. *Journal of Technology in Behavioral Science*, 6(3), 507–514. https://doi.org/10.1007/s41347-020-00189-w

3. Use of AI

Gemini Notebook (Google; accessed 21 October 2026) was used to produce a first review of the Introduction and propose revisions.

Claude (Anthropic; accessed 22 October 2026) was used to fact-check the Introduction against the cited sources, propose edits, review the document's formatting and layout and assist the author with the creation of a visual abstract.